A Monster Calls

By Patrick Ness

NARRATOR: **(Pg 1-2)** The monster showed up just after midnight. As they do. Conor was awake when it came. He'd had a nightmare. Well, not ***a*** nightmare. ***The*** nightmare. The one he'd been having a lot lately. The one with the darkness and the wind and the screaming. He'd told no one about the nightmare. Not his mum, obviously, but no one else either. What happened in the nightmare was something no one else ever needed to know. The nightmare was slipping from him, but there was something he couldn't put his finger on, something different . . . He listened, but all he could hear was the quiet house around him. Nothing. And then something. Something he realized was the thing that had woken him. Someone was calling his name . . .

MONSTER: *Conor.*

INTRODUCTION

Elizabeth Kubler Ross created a pathway to grief with her five stages: Denial, Anger, Bargaining, Depression, Acceptance. These stages are meant to allow grief to be understood, and the sufferer to let go. When Conor O'Malley finds out his mother is dying of cancer, he lives in denial and pent-up anger. No one talks about her death -- not her, not his grandmother, not his father, and not him. Not until he is forced to face the inevitable and deal with his grief. This grief takes the form of a monster. A monster who forces him to face the truth and guides him to acceptance.

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MONSTER: **(Pg 4)** *Conor.*

CONOR: *(heart thumping and impatient)* What?

NARRATOR: A cloud moved in front of the moon, and then passed, and the moon shone again. On a yew tree. Which now stood firmly in the middle of his backyard. And here was the monster.

MONSTER: **(Pg 136)** *The yew is a healing tree. It is the form I choose most to walk in.* **(Pg 137)** *If your mother can be healed, then the yew tree will do it.*

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CONOR: **(Pg 30)** What do you want from me?

MONSTER: **(Pg 36)** *You will tell me the truth.*

CONOR: The truth?

MONSTER: *Not just any truth. Your truth. You know that your truth, the one that you hide, Conor O'Malley, is the thing you are most afraid of. For this is why you called me.*

CONOR: *(confused)* Called you? I didn't call you— **(Pg 141)** "What's going to happen with my mum? You said you were a tree of healing. Well, I need you to heal!"

MONSTER: **(Pg 172)** *Conor O'Malley, I did not come to heal her, I came to heal you.*

CONOR: Me? I don't need healing. My mum's the one who's...

NARRATOR: But he couldn't say it. Even now he couldn't say it. Even though he'd known it all along. Of course he did, no matter how much he'd wanted to believe it wasn't true, he knew. But still, he couldn't say it. Couldn't say she was--

MONSTER: *It is time, for [your truth].*

NARRATOR: The mist surrounded them again. And once more, [he] was in the middle of the nightmare . . . **(Pg 174-175)** He recognized the clearing he was in, bordered on three sides by a dark forest; the fourth side, a cliff, flying off into further blackness. And on the cliff's edge, his mum. *(Actress assumes the character of Conor's Mum at the edge of a cliff)*

CONOR: *(drops to his knees, struggling to stand; he yells)* Mum! You have to get out of here!

MUM: *(Turning at the sound of his voice)* I'm fine, darling. There's nothing to worry about." *(Turns back to the cliff as if she's heard something calling her)*

CONOR: *(whispering to himself)* No.

NARRATOR: He pulled himself forward some more, but she was too far, too far to reach in time, and he felt so heavy-- There was a low sound from below the cliff. A rumbling, booming noise. Conor knew. It was too late. The real monster was coming. **(Pg 178-181)** With a roar, a cloud of burning darkness lifted two giant fists over the cliff top. They hovered in the air, over his mum as she tried to scramble back. But she was too weak, much too weak-At last, Conor could run. With a shout, he broke across the clearing, running so fast he nearly toppled over, and he threw himself toward her as the dark fists pulled her

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over the edge. And his hands caught hers. *(Actor lunges toward his mum as he speaks this last line)*

MUM: *(yelling)* Help me, Conor! Don't let go!

CONOR: I won't! I promise!

NARRATOR: The nightmare monster pulled harder, its fists straining around his mother's body. And she began to slip from Conor's grasp.

CONOR: No!

MUM: *(screaming in terror)* Please, Conor! Hold on to me!

NARRATOR: [But even as she said this, her hands] were slipping from his grasp, and she was getting heavier and heavier; The nightmare monster pulling harder and harder. He fell forward onto his chest from the weight of her. She screamed again.

CONOR: *(falling forward from the weight of his mum's grasp -- whispering)* Please! *Please! (he loses his grip and his mother falls; Conor screams) NO!*

MONSTER: *And here is the truth of Conor O'Malley.* **(Pg 185-189)** *You let her go.*

CONOR: *(shouting)* I didn't let her go! She fell!

MONSTER: *You must tell the truth or you will never leave this nightmare. You will be trapped here alone for the rest of your life.*

CONOR: *(still shouting and fighting the urge to speak)* I don't know what you mean!

MONSTER: *(low and threatening) You do know.*

NARRATOR: And there was a sudden quiet. Because yes, Conor knew. The truth. The real truth from the nightmare.

CONOR: Please don't make me, please don't make me say it.

MONSTER: *You let her go. You could have held on for longer, but you loosened your grip. You wanted her to go.*

CONOR: NO!

MONSTER: *You must speak the truth, Conor O'Malley. Say it. You must.*

CONOR: I can't.

MONSTER: *You let her go. Why? Tell me WHY! Before it's too late!*

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NARRATOR: A moan started in his throat, a moan that rose into a cry and then a loud wordless yell and he opened his mouth. And he spoke the truth.

CONOR: *(crying out)* I can't stand it anymore! I can't stand knowing that she'll go! I just want it to be over! I want it to be finished! I've known forever that she wasn't going to make it. And I started to think how much I wanted it to be over. How I couldn't stand the waiting anymore. I couldn't stand how alone it made me feel.

NARRATOR: He began to cry now, more than he thought he'd ever done. More than when he found out his mum was ill. **(Pg 203)** He wanted to ask the monster what was going to happen then, but he didn't dare. Because he knew. *(Actor assumes the role of Conor and pantomimes the following)* [And then they were in his mother's hospital room] **(Pg 202)** The monster's hands gently but firmly guided him toward [her]. **(Pg 203-205)** *(Conor looks down at her and takes her hand.)* She opened her eyes, briefly, catching him there. Then she closed them again. But she'd seen him. And he knew ***it*** was here. He knew there really was no going back. That ***it*** was going to happen. And he knew he was going to get through it. And at last, he spoke the final and total truth . . .

CONOR: *(tears falling from his eyes)* I don't want you to go.

MUM: *(in a heavy voice)* I know my love. I know.

CONOR: I don't want you to go. *(he leans forward and puts his arms around her, holding her)*

NARRATOR: And that was all he needed to say. He could feel the monster, holding him up and letting him stand there. *(Actor speaks from Actors position, still cradling Conor's mother in his arms)* He knew it would come. The moment she would slip from his grasp, no matter how tightly he held on. And by doing so, he could finally let her go.

MONSTER: *(whispering) But not this moment. Not just yet.*

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AWARD HISTORY

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